

Overview: Structured Choice Making

Structured choice making transforms overwhelming open-ended decisions into manageable selections between 2-3 carefully chosen options. Instead of asking "What would you like to do?" which can paralyse a pupil, you offer "Would you like the red pen or the blue pen?" This gives genuine agency while preventing decision paralysis. The pupil feels in control without being overwhelmed by infinite possibilities.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil freezes when given open-ended choices
- Takes excessive time to make simple decisions
- Becomes anxious or distressed when asked to choose
- Says "I don't know" to every choice question
- Defers all decisions to adults or peers

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Identify choice moments

Before the lesson, note moments where you naturally offer choices or where choices could give the pupil agency. Task setup, equipment selection, and work format are common opportunities.

Tip: Start with low-stakes choices (pen colour) before high-stakes ones (task selection).

2 Pre-select your options

Choose 2-3 options that are all acceptable to you. Never include an option you would reject if they chose it. All options must be genuine.

Teacher says: Think: "Would I be happy with any of these?" If not, remove that option.

Tip: Having a "wrong" choice destroys trust and makes future choices feel like traps.

3 Present choices visually

Where possible, show the options rather than just naming them. Hold up two pencils. Point to two seats. Display two task cards. Visual presentation reduces working memory load.

Teacher says: "You can use this pencil or this pencil. Which one?"

Tip: Physical objects are easier to choose between than abstract concepts.

4 Use simple, consistent language

Present choices with clear, predictable phrasing. "You can have A or B" or "Would you like X or Y?" Avoid long explanations of each option.

Teacher says: "Red or blue?" or "This seat or that seat?"

5 Give processing time

After presenting the choice, wait. Count to 10 in your head if needed. Do not repeat the options or add new information. Let them process.

Tip: Silence feels uncomfortable but is essential for processing.

6 Accept and move on

When they choose, accept it immediately without commentary. Do not ask "Are you sure?" or suggest the other option might be better.

Teacher says: "Blue. Great." Then continue with the lesson.

English Example: Creative writing task selection

Year 8 class starting creative writing. Pupil working at KS2 level becomes overwhelmed when given open choice of topic.

Prepare limited options

Teacher: Select 3 writing prompts that suit the pupil's interests and ability. Write each on a separate card with a simple image.

Pupil: N/A - this is teacher preparation.

Present choices visually

Teacher: Place three cards on desk. Say: "Today you're choosing your writing topic. Here are three options." Point to each briefly.

Pupil: Looks at the three cards. Can see all options at once.

Give processing time

Teacher: Say: "Take your time. Point to the one you want to write about." Wait silently. Do not repeat options.

Pupil: Considers options. Points to chosen card.

Confirm and remove other options

Teacher: Say: "The adventure story. Good choice." Remove other cards from desk. Provide writing resources for chosen topic.

Pupil: Sees decision is made. Other options are gone. Can focus on chosen task.

Maths Example: Choosing calculation method

Year 7 pupil working at KS2 level. Class is practising multiplication. Multiple methods have been taught but pupil freezes when asked to choose one.

Limit to two methods

Teacher: Prepare two method cards: grid method and repeated addition. These are the only options for this pupil.

Pupil: N/A - preparation.

Present the choice

Teacher: Place both cards in front of pupil. Say: "For this question, you can use grid method or repeated addition. Which one?"

Pupil: Looks at both cards. Familiar with both methods.

Support the decision

Teacher: If pupil hesitates, say: "Both will work. Just pick the one you want to use today." Wait.

Pupil: Points to grid method.

Reinforce and continue

Teacher: Say: "Grid method. Here's your grid paper." Remove other card. Pupil works through problem using chosen method.

Pupil: Uses grid method. Completes calculation. Success with chosen approach.

Science Example: Recording experimental results

Year 9 practical lesson. Pupil working at KS2 level needs to record results but freezes when asked "How do you want to record this?"

Prepare recording options

Teacher: Create two recording template options: a simple table and a labelled diagram with spaces for numbers.

Pupil: N/A - preparation.

Offer structured choice

Teacher: Show both templates. Say: "You need to record your results. You can use this table or this diagram. Which one works better for you?"

Pupil: Examines both templates.

Provide decision support

Teacher: Point to each in turn. Say: "Table - you write numbers in boxes. Diagram - you label the picture. Either one is fine."

Pupil: Says "The table" or points to it.

Confirm and proceed

Teacher: Hand over the table template. Say: "Good. Write your first measurement here." Point to first cell.

Pupil: Has clear recording format. Begins entering data.